

FREE CHECKLIST

The Remote Resume Checklist

27 checks that get your resume past the software and past a hiring manager who reads 200 a week.

WHAT IS INSIDE

- 27 yes/no checks, section by section
- 6 before/after bullet rewrites for remote roles
- A one-page keyword map to tailor any resume in 10 minutes

A remote resume has two readers, and they want different things. The parser wants clean text in a predictable order. The hiring manager wants one answer fast: can this person do the job from where they are, on our hours, without being watched? Most resumes fail the first reader on layout and the second on evidence.

Work through the sections in order. Tick each check honestly. Anything unticked is a fix you can make today.

01 1. Format and ATS safety

The software reads before any human does. Make its job boring.

- ☐ The file is a single-column .docx or a text-based PDF. Test: open the PDF, drag to select a line, copy it. If nothing selects, the page is an image (Canva and some Figma exports do this) and the parser sees a blank.

- ☐ Your name, email, phone with country code, and location sit in the body of the page, not in a header or footer. Some parsers skip headers and footers. Do not bet your contact details on which kind this company bought.

- ☐ Section headings use the plain words parsers map to: Experience, Education, Skills. Not "Where I've been" or "Toolbox". An unusual heading may get its section misfiled, and a misfiled Experience section is an empty resume.

- ☐ No tables, text boxes, two-column layouts or icons carry real content. A three-column skills grid flattens into one scrambled sentence.

- ☐ Dates use the month as a word and a plain hyphen: "Mar 2023 - Present". A US-configured parser and a UK-configured parser read 03/04/2023 as different months, and an en dash can flatten into a stray character in some text extractors. The hyphen never does.

- ☐ Every acronym appears once in full and once short: "Search Engine Optimisation (SEO)". A screening search may look for either form. Give it both and you cannot lose.

- ☐ Links are written out as full URLs: linkedin.com/in/yourname, github.com/yourname, yoursite.com/writing. Not "Portfolio" underlined in blue. Flattening keeps the words and drops the link, so the manager gets the word "Portfolio" and nowhere to click.

- ☐ No photo, no skill-rating bars, no icons in place of the words "Phone" and "Email". An icon flattens to nothing, leaving a bare 11-digit number the parser cannot classify.

- ☐ The file is named FirstName-LastName-Role.pdf. The recruiter who forwards it to the hiring manager sees the file name in the email. "resume_final_v3.pdf" tells them nothing

What the parser actually sees

A parser does not see your layout. It flattens the document into one long string, reading top to bottom and left to right across the whole page. With two columns, line one of your sidebar gets glued to line one of your experience, and so on down. Text boxes, images and, in some tools, headers and footers never make it into that string. The five-second test: Ctrl+A, Ctrl+C in your PDF, paste into Notepad or TextEdit. If a stranger could read that text in order and find your phone number, the parser can too. If you fail three or more checks above, do not fight your template. The free resume creator at remoteworldwide.net/dashboard/resume outputs a single-column layout with plain headings and contact details in the body, which is this whole section handled.

02 2. Remote signals

The things a remote hiring manager scans for before reading a single bullet.

- ☐ Your location line answers "when can I reach you": "Lagos, Nigeria · UTC+1 · available 09:00-17:00 ET". A city on its own makes the manager do time-zone maths, and a manager on resume 140 of 200 will not.

- ☐ The word "remote" sits against at least one past role: "Remote, reporting to a team in Berlin". Hybrid, contract and freelance count. If you have never worked remote, do not write "remote-ready" anywhere; show async evidence instead.

- ☐ At least one bullet uses an async tool as a verb, not as a noun in a skills list: "wrote weekly updates in Notion", "recorded Loom walkthroughs", "tracked decisions in Linear". A tool you have shipped with is proof; a tool you have listed is a claim.

- ☐ There is a link to something you wrote: a README, a changelog, a help-centre article, a public post, a case study. Remote teams run on writing. One artefact beats "excellent written communication".

- ☐ One bullet shows you worked while nobody else was online: "handled EU-morning escalations before the US team started". It answers the question the manager is quietly asking: what happens when I am asleep and something breaks?

- ☐ One bullet shows self-management: something you scoped, ran and shipped without daily check-ins. Name the duration. "Ran the migration solo over 6 weeks" tells the manager they will not be babysitting.

- ☐ If you are outside the hiring country, one line says how you can be engaged: "Open to a contractor agreement, or employment through an employer of record such as Deel or Remote.com". These are different things. As a contractor you invoice the company yourself. An employer of record hires you on the company's behalf in your country and runs your payroll. Name the one you can do, or both. Unanswered, this question quietly removes non-local candidates from the pile.

Here is how a remote hiring manager reads: location line, current job title, first bullet under the current job. In my experience that takes a few seconds. If those three say "reachable, relevant, self-running", the manager reads the rest. If not, the next resume is one click away.

Put your country in the location line. It feels risky when you are applying from somewhere the company has never hired, but the posting's eligibility line already decided this. If they take contractors worldwide, your country tells them they can engage you. If they only hire in five

named countries and yours is not one, no location trick survives the offer stage, and hiding it costs you and them a month. Overlap hours, named async tools and a link to your writing do the work adjectives cannot: each one can be checked from the manager's chair without a call.

03 3. Impact bullets

Six rewrites. Each one turns a duty into evidence that a distributed team can trust.

BEFORE

Responsible for customer support tickets.

AFTER

Resolved 40-60 Zendesk tickets a day for US customers from UTC+3, holding 92% CSAT over 12 months; wrote 30 help-centre articles that cut repeat billing tickets by roughly a third.

Why it works: Volume plus time zone shows sustained output while the US team slept. The articles are written-communication proof the manager can go and read.

BEFORE

Worked with the marketing team on campaigns.

AFTER

Ran 14 email campaigns end to end for a team spread across 5 time zones; briefs, copy and reporting lived in Notion so nobody waited on a meeting.

Why it works: "Across 5 time zones" and "nobody waited on a meeting" say async coordination without using the word. That is the skill a distributed marketing lead is hiring for.

BEFORE

Developed features for the web app.

AFTER

Shipped 22 features in a React/Node codebase over 18 months, each with a written RFC and PR description; 90% merged without a synchronous review call.

Why it works: Remote engineering teams review in writing. A bullet that counts RFCs and async merges shows you already work the way they do.

BEFORE

Managed projects and deadlines.

AFTER

Led a 6-person contractor team across 4 countries; a weekly written status in Slack replaced stand-ups and we hit 11 of 12 milestones on time.

Why it works: Contractors in four countries is remote leadership, not generic project management. Replacing stand-ups with written status is the specific behaviour managers look for.

BEFORE

Good at working independently.

AFTER

Sole designer at a 9-person remote startup for 2 years; recorded a Loom design review every Friday so an engineering team 12 hours ahead could respond overnight.

Why it works: The claim becomes a habit with a cadence and a tool. "12 hours ahead" shows you have already solved the overlap problem the manager is worried about.

BEFORE

Handled bookkeeping for the company.

AFTER

Closed the books monthly for a US LLC from Nigeria using QuickBooks Online and Gusto; cut month-end close from 9 days to 4.

Why it works: Cross-border work with the employer's own tools removes the "will this work from there?" doubt. The number proves it improved, not just happened.

1**Start with a verb that points at something that still exists**

Shipped, resolved, closed, wrote, migrated, recorded, published. Each one names an output the manager could go and look at: a PR, a ticket queue, a document, a video. "Responsible for" and "assisted with" describe being in the room. A remote manager never saw the room, so the verb has to carry the proof.

2**Add the scope, and make it geographic**

Who, where, and when. "For US customers", "across 4 countries", "for a team 12 hours ahead", "before the US team started". Scope is where remote evidence lives. A bullet with no place or time zone in it is a bullet any office worker could have written.

End with a number, or with a cadence

Count, percentage, duration or money. Pull it from the tools that already recorded it: Zendesk shows tickets per day, GitHub shows PRs merged, your calendar shows how many Friday reviews you ran. If you do not have an exact figure, use an honest range: "40-60 tickets a day". If your role has no metrics at all (admin, junior support, coordination), use a cadence and a duration instead: "sent the Monday summary every week for 14 months"; "covered the shared inbox solo for 6 weeks". A cadence is the remote number. It proves you did the thing repeatedly with nobody standing over you.

04 4. Keywords

Mirror the posting's language. Do not stuff it.

- 1 Paste the posting into a blank document**
 Highlight every skill, tool or noun phrase that appears twice or more. Repeated terms are the best proxy you have for what the team cares about. Nobody writes "async" three times by accident.
- 2 Split must-haves from nice-to-haves**
 Posting language tells you: "required", "must", "you have" are filters. "Bonus", "nice to have", "familiarity with" are not. Your top five keywords come from the first list only.
- 3 Use their phrasing, not your own**
 If they wrote PostgreSQL, write PostgreSQL somewhere, even if you also say Postgres. If they wrote Customer Success, do not translate it to Client Success. Some screening tools normalise synonyms and some do not, and you cannot see which one they bought. Casing does not matter; word choice does.
- 4 Mirror their word for remote, or supply one**
 Distributed, remote-first, work from anywhere, async, EST overlap: whichever phrase they used, use it in your location line and once in a bullet. If the posting says nothing about time zone or overlap, which is common, look up the company's headquarters in the site footer or About page and offer overlap with that city: "4 hours of overlap with London business hours". If the team is clearly spread out, offer a window instead: "a fixed 4-hour overlap anywhere between UTC-5 and UTC+2". Silence on overlap reads as "has not thought about it".
- 5 Place each keyword twice, in two kinds of place**
 Once in your summary or headline, once inside a bullet that has a number. A keyword that lives only in a skills list matches the software and bores the human.

WEAK PHRASING	STRONG PHRASING	WHAT CHANGED
Familiar with Slack and Zoom	Ran a 30-person async support channel in Slack; Zoom only for weekly 1:1s	Tool became a behaviour with a size
Works well in a team	Coordinated daily handoffs with a QA team in Manila from UTC-5	Named the place and the time zone
Strong written communication	Author of the onboarding guide used by 45 new hires (link)	Claim became an artefact the manager can open

WEAK PHRASING	STRONG PHRASING	WHAT CHANGED
Flexible with working hours	Committed to 09:00-13:00 PT overlap; async outside those hours	Vague became a schedule in their time zone
Experience with remote work	Fully remote since 2021 across 3 employers in the UK and US	Duration and geography added
Self-motivated	Started the weekly changelog nobody asked for; 60 editions since 2023	Unprompted initiative with a cadence

- ☐ Each of the posting's top five keywords appears in at least one bullet that also contains a number, not only in the skills list.
- ☐ No keyword appears more than three times. A manager who reads 200 a week spots stuffing in a glance and reads it as a template, not a person.
- ☐ The posting's own word for remote (distributed, remote-first, async, work from anywhere) appears in your location line or summary. If the posting has no such word, your overlap line names their headquarters city instead.
- ☐ Keywords copied in from a previous application that this posting never mentions have been removed. Stray keywords tell the manager this resume was not written for them.

05 5. The keyword map

Fill this in by hand for each role. It takes about 10 minutes and it is the whole tailoring job.

Print this or copy it into a note. One map per application. Once the six rows are filled, every edit to the resume is mechanical: put the keyword where the map says it goes, put the number in the first bullet, put the overlap in the location line. Log the application in the tracker at remoteworldwide.net/dashboard/tracker with the map attached, so when the interview comes you remember which version they saw.

Role you want (exact title
from the posting)

The posting's top 5 keywords
(exact spelling)

Where each keyword appears
in your resume (section +
bullet)

Your strongest number for
this role

Time-zone overlap you can
offer, in their time zone

Tools you have shipped with
that the posting names

06 6. Final pass

Seven checks before you press send. Do them in this order.

- ☐ Copy-paste test passed: the whole resume pasted into a plain-text editor reads top to bottom in the right order, with your contact details at the top.

- ☐ The overlap line is expressed in the posting's time zone, not yours, and it matches the hours they asked for. If they said "4 hours of PT overlap" and you wrote "available 09:00-17:00 WAT", they still have to do the maths.

- ☐ Your location line names your country, and the posting's eligibility line (which countries, contractor or employer of record) allows it. If it does not, this application is a coin toss. Spend the hour on one that does.

- ☐ Every link opens in a private browser window. A portfolio behind a login, a Notion page set to private or a Google Doc that asks for access is a dead link to the manager.

- ☐ Phone number has a country code, and one word says how you take calls: "WhatsApp", "Signal" or "phone". First calls are usually booked through a scheduling link and held on Zoom or Meet, so the number itself rarely matters; the word removes the one excuse a screener has to skip an international one.

- ☐ Length is one page for under roughly 8 years of experience, two pages at most beyond that, as a rule of thumb. When cutting, drop the earliest office-based job before you drop a remote bullet.

- ☐ The file name, the headline under your name and the summary all contain the role title from the posting, spelled the way they spelled it. It is the first thing matched by software and the first thing read by a human.

Now see how the software scores it

You have done the human read. Now run the machine read. The free ATS scorer on your Remote Worldwide dashboard scores your resume against a job posting you paste in and lists the top missing keywords. Fix what it flags, re-run it, then apply.

Score my resume →